

Chapter 1

A bridge above a wild river at night. Cars drive by. A teenage girl stands at the barrier. She looks tired and wears black baggy pants and a black vest. You can't make out her face in the darkness. Slowly the girl moves closer and closer to the edge of the bridge. She looks down and looks at her phone one last time. 0 notifications. Then she climbs over the fence. She looks at her wrists and closes her eyes.

Then she jumps.

"BEEP BEEP BEEP BEEP BEE-"

"Ugh" Sylvia says as she stops her alarm. She looks at her watch. 6:30 am. Why did she choose this school again? After a few minutes she gets out of bed. How late did she go to sleep? Quickly she dresses up and checks what lessons she has. Math, French, geography and biology. Sylvia goes downstairs to the living room. Bottles, empty wine bottles everywhere. Her mother is probably still asleep.

7:12 am.

"Shit!" Sylvia grabs her bag and runs outside. She needs to catch her bus. After running 3 minutes she sees the bus in the distance. "Wait! Wait for me!" She shouts. Getting closer, closer, just 5 more meters...

"Yes" She has made it to the bus and sits down. Why is she so excited to catch the bus? Its not like school is any fun. In fact, she'd rather never go to school again. But her teachers are already watching her closely, they know where she lives and if she doesn't arrive at school they'd certainly wait at her house, and when her mother would hear the news that would mean-

"End stop! Everyone out!" The bus driver shouts.

"There you are, Sylvia. Just in time." The teacher says.

Sylvia walks to her seat, next to Sam.

"Late again, fatty" Sam whispers. "Eventually the teachers will stop keeping an eye shut, I hope they'll give you detention"

Sylvia doesn't react. She's thinking about last night. She remembers her mom coming home late at night, and

she was drunk. Really drunk. She got mad at Sylvia because she didn't clean the living room. She remembers sitting in her room, Crying. And she remembers the lonely feeling. Like no one would notice if she would just... Disappear. She remembers the pain. The urge. The blood.

It's become a given that Sylvia wears long sleeves. No one questions it. Probably because no one cares. Sometimes Sylvia wishes someone would ask: "Why do you always cover your arms? Are you okay?" But why would anyone ask that? She's just the weird kid, The fat kid, The kid to make fun of. She's the oldest of her class. She's almost 15, while most other kids are 13 or just became 14.

"And, Sylvia, can you explain the formula to us?"

"Um- uh- well..." Sylvia stutters.

"Well surely you did your homework, Right?" The entire class looks at her.

"That's the fifth time this month. I'd like to talk to you when this hour's over, Sylvia Evans."

"How is it going-"

"Fine."

"Okay, then why don't you ever do your homework?"

The teacher looks deep into Sylvia's eyes. She has glasses, those typical teacher glasses that are rectangular. Sylvia guesses her age at around 60 years old.

"Um, I just- forgot it."

That's not true. She was lying in her bed because she was exhausted from school. And when she finally wanted to start her homework, Her mom came home and-

"How is your home situation?" Her teacher asked, as if she could read Sylvia's mind.

"Fine." She replied, again a little too fast.

"Your father isn't home that much, right?"

"My dad's dead."

"Oh, that must be very painful for you." Her teacher says empathically, though she doesn't look very empathic.

"Nah, when he died I was only 5."

Again, not true. He died 2 years ago, just before she would go to high school.

“And your mother? Does she care well for you?”

“Of course! Why are you so worried about my home situation?”

Sylvia already knows the answer. Her mother once went to school to hear about Sylvia’s bad grades, completely drunk.

“Oh, I’m just curious why your grades have been going down so bad. In the first year you were getting straight A’s, but now you might not make it to third year.”

Sylvia bites her lip. If she’d fail this year her mother would personally hang her on the highest tree. And that might just be the best way to deal with a daughter like her.

Chapter 2

RINGGG!

“Yes, finally!” Sylvia thinks. Though it really just is going

from one hell to another. She still hasn't decided what's worse: home or school. She walks through the hall, on the way to the lockers.

"There she is again: Miss fatty!"

"I've heard she's a lesbian!"

"Ha! As if girls would want her! She doesn't even have normal friends!"

Sometimes Sylvia would want to come to school with a gun one day, and shoot every bully she sees. And when the police arrive, she'd shoot herself in the head. Sadly getting a gun isn't easy. And even if she did have a gun she wouldn't have the courage to actually hurt people.

In the bus Sylvia thinks about what those kids said. Maybe she is lesbian. She had never had a crush on a boy, but also never on a girl. One thing she knows for sure is that she's fat. And she also doesn't have any friends. She used to have lots of friends, in middle school. But they all went to other schools. She failed her last exam before high school because her father died. Her mother was never the same after that. She started using alcohol to numb the pain. Her mom used to be very kind. Sylvia remembers her mom playing with her,

and feeding ducks in the park together. Now she's just a volcano that sleeps most of the time but sometimes erupts. What would her mother do if she died? She'd probably just drink more alcohol, that's her way to deal with every problem. That is, thinking her mother would care. She probably wouldn't care if she'd be gone. No one would.

Sylvia looks at her watch. 02:23 am. Her mom is already asleep. She got drunk again and now she's laying on the couch. Sylvia is hungry. Has she even eaten? She can't remember. She runs downstairs and opens the fridge. Wine, wine, wine, wine. No food? She checks all of the little cabinets, but she only found some chocolate and an old 16-pack of ice lollies. "No, don't eat that! You're already fat enough!" A voice in her head says. But she's so hungry... Well, just one piece of chocolate won't hurt, right?

"Ugh" Sylvia feels dirty. As if she stepped in a big pile of cow dung. She has ate all of the chocolate and 14 ice lollies.

"You will always stay a fatty, you can't even control

yourself” The voice says. “If you can’t stop the urge, Then we’ll do it this way.”

4:02 am. Sylvia is laying on her bed. Her left arm is covered in blood, and so is her bed. But who even cares. It’s not like her mother ever comes into her room. Her mouth tastes weird. Making yourself puke was harder than she thought. She hears noise downstairs.

“Shit! That’s probably mom” Sylvia thinks. She slowly sneaks to her door to close it. Then she hears her mom open the back door.

“What?” She thinks. Her mother just walked out, at 4 am.

Chapter 3

Lunch break. Sylvia hasn’t brought lunch with her. She sits in the corner of the hall, drawing in a book, listening to music. She looks up. A girl is standing in front of her.

“Nice drawing!” She says.

“Um, th- thanks!” Sylvia walks away.

"Hey! Can you teach me how to draw like that?" The girl asks.

"Uh- well-" Something about this girl makes Sylvia feel weird. Uncomfortable and comfortable at the same time.

RINGGG!

"Sorry, maybe later!" Sylvia says to her as she walks to her classroom.

"What did you do? Finally someone actually talks to you normally, and you just fuck it all up! Now she probably thinks you're just a weird asocial kid." Its that voice again.

"Can't you just shut up? I'm trying my best" Sylvia says back.

"Ha, Miss fatty talks to air! Too bad you don't have real friends!"

Sylvia doesn't even react. She used to react to those people, but it only made it worse.

Her mom wasn't home in the morning. Sylvia wonders where she could have gone. Wouldn't it be nice if she never returned? Then Sylvia would have the house all for herself. There wouldn't be a mother that would hit

Sylvia if she was drunk.

Sylvia thinks about what happened in the lunch break. That girl actually gave her a compliment! But why does she feel so weird around that girl? Maybe they can become friends?

"No, because you stuttered the entire time and just acted like a weirdo" The voice says.

RINGGG!

Sylvia walks through the halls, ignores the usual shouting, and opens the door to the lockers.

"Hey! You!" Sylvia looks to her left and sees the girl again.

Sylvia stops and says back: "Hi, uhh, do you still want to learn how to draw?"

"Don't fuck this up now" The voice in the back of her head says.

"Sure! Can we go to your house?" She asks. "My name is Jamie, by the way"

"My name is Sylvia! But no, can we go to your house, or maybe stay at school"

"Yeah, we can stay at school if you want, Sylvia" Jamie says.

"Bye! See you tomorrow!" Jamie waves to Sylvia as she walks away to her bus.

"Bye!"

"Holy shit! I think you finally managed to get a friend!"
The voice says.

What even is that voice? Are there really people in Sylvia's head, or is it just her thoughts?

Sylvia feels glad Jamie didn't look at her other drawings in her book. She usually draws lonely, depressed scenes. But this lunch break she decided to draw a normal person in high detail and make a character out of it.

"How late is it?" Sylvia thinks.

05:46 pm.

"Shit! I need to get home by 6!"

Back at her house she opens the door. Its 06:16 pm.

"Mom?" Sylvia shouts.

No answer.

"Mom? I'm home!"

No answer again.

Sylvia walks upstairs to her mother's bedroom. There she lays. Her mother, deep sleeping, probably drunk. But then, on the floor next to her mother's bedside drawer, she sees a small bottle.

"Sleeping medication..." Sylvia gasps. The bottle is half empty.

"911, what is your emergency?" Sounds through the phone.

"My mom, she- I think she committed suicide!" Sylvia is crying. She thought it'd be better if her mom was gone, but now that she thinks about it...

"Calm down ma'am, are you safe right now?"

"Yes"

"What's your location?"

"Wisher street 34 in Manhattan" Sylvia replies.

"Okay, we have vehicles coming in your direction, they'll be there in 5 minutes."

Chapter 4

Sylvia is asleep, in a chair next to her mother's bed in the hospital. Again, she dreams about the bridge. Now that her mother's probably dead, she might as well make an end to it too. The doctors said that her mother was in critical condition. She had, of course, taken an overdose on sleeping medication.

Sylvia wakes up at 11:03 am. She looks to her right and sees her mother. She looks so... Helpless, so childish. Then one thought hits her: "What about the price?" Medical care isn't free, how will they ever pay this? They were never rich, but now they're at a low point. Her mom spends all her money on wine, and Sylvia just eats microwave food. If she even eats at all. They're already in debt, and if they have to pay for this too...

Her mom turns around in her bed. Sylvia looks up.

Her mom looks around the hospital room.

"Hey, Sylv, are you here too?" She says with a sleepy voice.

"Yes, without me you'd be-" Sylvia stops mid sentence. Should she say this? Maybe her mom has lost memory and she can tell her mom that she's the best mom ever

and never drinks.

"I'd be... dead." Her mom replies.

There's an awkward silence between the two.

"Yes, you almost were"

"Why did you bring me here? If it had just worked it would all be over. But now we have to pay a shit ton of money because we don't have health insurance!" Her mom looks angry.

"As if I'm happy to be alive!" Sylvia replies.

Her mother looks her in the eyes.

"You. Should. Be. Happy. To. Be. Alive." Her mother looks like she's about to explode of anger.

Sylvia walks out of the room.

"I hope they cut your live support!" She shouts.

Sylvia walks away from the hospital. There's a bridge over a small river that's 2 kilometers away.

Should she go? Should she just end it, now that she can?

"Yes, walk to the bridge and jump" The voice says.

She's been dreaming about this type of thing for months.

"But Jamie... She seemed so kind!" Sylvia says to back to herself.

"Jamie has enough friends. She probably only approached you because she feels sorry for you. Jump"

Sylvia has arrived at the bridge. There's lots of people walking by. She looks at her phone. 0 notifications. No one wondering if she's okay, no one sending a random meme, no one who cares. Should she jump? She stands at the edge of the bridge, against the fencing. She looks down to the water below.

"No. I'm not jumping." Sylvia thinks.

"Yes you are, do you want to suffer even more? Quick, end it. Now!" Why is she debating in her head?

PING! A notification pops up on her phone.

[unknown number]: Hi Sylvia! (I'm Jamie btw)

Is that really Jamie? How did she get her number?

You: Hi! How did u get my number?

[unknown number]: Via the school administration. I was worried cuz u weren't at school

You: Yeah sorry there's something with my mom but ill

be at school tomorrow!

Jamie: Ok!

Jamie: Wanna come over to my house?

Sylvia feels tired and is still standing at the edge of the bridge.

You: No sorry maybe later im reallllly tired ._.

Jamie: Dw, ill see u tomorrow!

Sylvia starts walking back home.

PING!

Jamie: What happened to ur mom then?

Sylvia turns off her phone again.

Jamie: I can see that u read my message. What happened to ur mom??

Jamie: Sylvia?

You: Ill tell u later sorry

Sylvia is staring at Jamie's profile picture. Jamie looks beautiful in that picture. Her long blonde hair shines in the sunlight and her kind eyes stare right into the camera. Sylvia thinks. Why does she feel so weird around Jamie? And why did she say no? She'd love to go to Jamie's house.

"Well, no is no. You fucked up" The annoying voice says.

Chapter 5

Sylvia opens the front door. Everything is just too much. She walks upstairs and lets herself fall into her bed.

"Ugh, what time is it?" Sylvia just woke up. Her watch reads 03:39 am. She's hungry. Really hungry.

"No, you're not gonna eat again!" The voice says.

"But I'm hungry! If I don't eat now I might die!"

"So? It's not like anyone cares!"

"Jamie does"

"We've had this conversation before. Jamie has enough other friends."

"But-"

"You're not eating"

Sylvia starts to cry. She puts on her headphones and lays still for one hour straight, Trying to hide the tears from view. As if someone ever looked at her.

"You know, you should probably run away from home"
The voice is starting to get weird.

"What?"

"Mom doesn't care about you, and school is also just straight up hell. If you run away, you'll be free to do whatever you want!"

"True, but what about Jamie?"

"You know what's with Jamie"

"I'm not running away. That's just it"

"Well then you'll stay home and your mom will keep beating you up and you'll keep getting bullied and-"

Sylvia has grabbed her razor.

"You'll fail this year and-"

One line. Two lines. Three. Four.

"You'll never get any friends and-"

Blood is starting to slowly flow out of the fresh cuts.

"And you'll never get Jamie to love you-"

"What!?" Sylvia has thought this before. Maybe she is a lesbian and fell in love with Jamie.

"Don't you get it? It's obvious! You. Are. Falling. For. Jamie"

"Is there something wrong with that then?"

"No, it's just sad because Jamie doesn't want you"

"Well I don't want her either"

"Yeah right. You really are a romantic nitwit. Let me make this clear. You wanna kiss Jamie"

"N- no?"

"Doubting it, huh? You should never doubt me! I'm the all knowing voice in the back of your head" The voice says, full of triumph.

"I'm not lesbian!"

After arguing with herself for another hour, Sylvia finally falls asleep.

"BEEP BEEP BEEP BEEP BEEP BEEP BEE-"

Sylvia slams on her alarm clock and gets out of bed.

Where did her mom go that night when she walked out?

To the night club? To some illegal drug dealer? She'll never know. Maybe her mom even attempted suicide multiple times, but failed without anyone knowing.

Her arm hurts, Her head hurts, her stomach hurts, everything just hurts. What's the last time she has eaten? Sylvia can't remember. She opens the fridge to see if there's any food in there. Wine, wine, wine, wine. "You might as well just drink some. There's no other food" The voice says.

"Drink wine? Are you crazy?"

"Just drink it, it'll make you numb to the pain"

Sylvia arrived at school 15 minutes late. She feels a little funny, because of the wine. She didn't look how much she drank, but her mother probably won't notice anyways. She enters the classroom.

"And, Miss Evans, can you explain why you're 15 minutes late?" Her teacher asks

"Well, you see, our bus had... Uhh... a delay. Yes, we were stuck in traffic" Sylvia's head gets red.

"Sorry, but sadly I take the same bus as you, and there's never any traffic on that road. That's detention for you"

RINGGG! Lunch break. Sylvia's head hurts a lot. Probably because of the wine. Jamie sits down next to her.

"Hi Sylvia!" Jamie says, as happy as always.

"Hi"

"What happened to your mom yesterday?"

Sylvia thinks. Should she tell Jamie the truth?

"Oh, nothing, I just overreacted" Sylvia says, after a few seconds.

"Okay, nice to have you back!"

"Yup"

"Is there something you're worried about, Sylvia?"

"No, I'm just really tired and I have a headache"

"Just know you can always tell me if there's something"

"Is there something you're worried about?"

"Well, yeah. Do you see that guy over there?"

"Yes..."

"I- I like him. Like really really like him. But I don't know how to tell him and I'm just some random girl and he's so handsome and- Sylvia?"

Sylvia runs away.

"Sylvia! Come back! Did I say something wrong? What-"

Chapter 6

Sylvia closes the door of the toilet. She reaches in her pocket and grabs the small blade she always brings with her.

"See? I told you! You're in love with Jamie! Ha! Too bad she's just straight and normal" The voice echoes through her head.

"No! I just- I"

"Sylvia?" Jamie screams through the school toilets. Sylvia stays silent.

"Sylvia! What did I say wrong?"

RINGGG!

Jamie walks away. Saved by the bell.

Sylvia feels dizzy, way dizzier than normal. She sits down in the corner of the toilet. She grabs the blade, rolls her sleeve up and presses her arm against the wall. She put her headphones on her head and starts cutting. 1 line. 2 lines. 3 lines. 4 lines. The cuts quickly turn red. 5 lines. 6 lines... 7... 8... Sylvia stops. She looks at her arm. Why is she hurting herself? If she really wants to punish herself she should just commit suicide.

"Do it, then"

"How?"

"Just cut those big veins in your lower arm"

"But..."

"Do. It. No-one would care if you stayed. And shut up"

about Jamie you just keep talking shit about how she would love you but she doesn't because you just ran away plus she's straight and likes that stupid Sam don't you understand that you're a waste of air that you could just vanish and no-one would notice don't you get that they could find your body and just leave it laying on the floor don't you understand that you don't even have a 'mother' anymore don't you understand that you just don't matter"

The voice keeps talking, faster and faster.

"Don't you understand how much people hate you don't you understand that no-one truly loves you don't you know that this voice you're hearing is just you as you are yes you're really this horrible of a person and I personally hope you are smart enough to know how to cut the right veins I just hope you die"

Sylvia lies on the floor, her head sticking out under the walls of the toilet compartment. There's a small pool of blood around her left arm. Sylvia wakes up. She looks around, confused. What happened? The only thing she knows is that she needs to get the hell out of there. She pulls herself out of the toilet compartment and rolls her sleeves down again. She exits the toilets and runs to the hallway. A few younger kids walk by, Disturbed by the little drips of blood hanging from Sylvia's sleeves.

"Don't be afraid, it's nothing!" Sylvia tries to smile. The kids scream.

“Shit!” Sylvia runs away to the entrance of the school and walks out. It’s raining. Where does she go? The hospital? No way. They’ll see all of her other scars and wounds. Sylvia eventually finds a bridge she can sit under and hide for the rain. She rolls up her sleeve again. There’s half dried blood, everywhere. How long was she unconscious? Thankfully no one found her. Sylvia checks her phone. There’s 5 notifications.

Today, 2:12 pm

Jamie: Sylv?

Today, 1:50 pm

Jamie: Pls respond Sylvia I rly hope ur ok

Today, 1:35 pm

Jamie: Sylvia r u ok? Ive been trying to call u but u don’t respond and im worried abt u pls respond

Today, 1:34 pm

Jamie: *23 missed calls*

Today, 9:56 am

Mom: Hey, my dear Sylvia.

I'm really sorry about what I said and did the last 2 years. After your dad died, I just... Couldn't handle it anymore. I had been dealing with mental health issues in the past, but Josh helped me get through. When he disappeared, I fell back into my old habits of drinking to numb the pain. I tried committing suicide multiple times in the week that you found me. But I was too scared to really do it. So I tried it in the most painless and peaceful way. Thankfully you found me. THANKFULLY. Lying in this hospital bed, sober, made me think about what I did. I obviously can't remember everything I did, as I was drunk, but I do remember small pieces. I'm really sorry what I did to you, to us. I hope we can fix this mess I made back up.

Endless love, your Mother. <3

(Can you throw away all of the remaining wine? I have some in by bedside drawer and the rest is in the fridge.)